

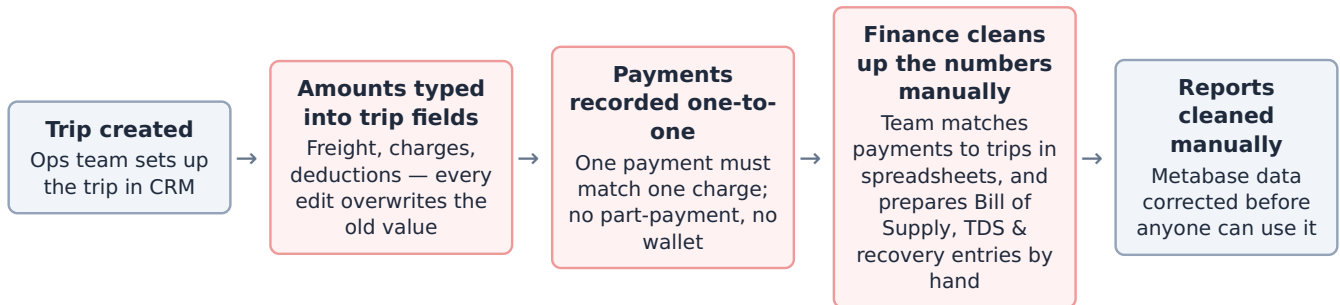
Marketplace Ledger — Build vs Buy

Decision note for go-ahead • Recommendation: build the ledger in-house as the system of record • June 2026

1 How money flows today (current process)



Today both sides are mixed into the same trip fields — there is no separate “money in” (AR) vs “money out” (AP) view, so margin is invisible.



Result: 500+ finance hours every month on manual work • disputed balances we cannot defend • payments are our #1 support-ticket driver

2 Gaps in the current process and system

No history. Edits overwrite old values, so we cannot show what a balance was on a given date. When a payment is disputed, we have nothing to point to.

Balances drift. Totals across a trip stop adding up over time, creating reconciliation mismatches between us, fleet owners and LSPs.

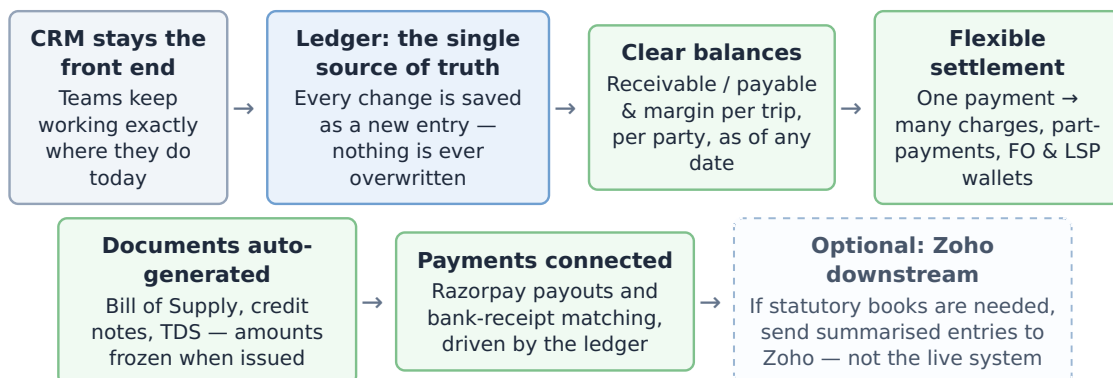
Rigid payments. One payment cannot settle many charges, be paid in parts, or sit in a wallet. Overpayments and cancelled-trip advances have no clean home.

No clear per-party picture. We can't reliably see what each LSP owes us, what we owe each fleet owner, or our margin per trip.

Compliance is manual. Bill of Supply, credit notes and TDS are computed and issued by hand — ~37 compliance line items, all error-prone.

Heavy ongoing cost. All of the above lands on the finance team as repeated manual effort, month after month.

3 What is needed to solve this



Scope note on “wallet”: this is only a basic internal balance in our ledger — to track overpayments, credits/debits and cross-trip settlement. We are **not** building a full-fledged wallet product: no money is stored and there is no external wallet integration.

Result: defensible balances on any date • automated compliance • 500+ finance hours/month back • ledger visible to FOs & LSPs later for trust

4 Build vs Buy — the decision in one view

What matters	Build in-house (recommended)	Buy — Zoho Books as the live system
Fits our business model	✓ Designed for a broker: per-trip receivable (LSP) and payable (FO) with our margin in between.	✗ Treats us as one company issuing invoices. No concept of two counterparties on one trip, or our margin.
Wallets & flexible settlement	✓ Basic internal wallet for FOs and LSPs — a ledger balance for overpayments, credits and cross-trip settlement only (not a full wallet product; no external integration). One payment can cover many charges or be part-paid.	✗ No per-party wallets; settlement forced into Zoho's invoice/bill structure.
Work we still do either way	✓ One system to maintain. Business logic already lives in the marketplace.	✗ Same work, plus more: onboard every FO & LSP into Zoho, keep records in sync, format data to Zoho's rules.
When something breaks	✓ We see and fix issues in our own system, directly.	✗ Sync failures still land on our team — we carry the break-fix burden but debug across two systems.
Speed of change	✓ New charge types, tax rules, wallet rules: we change and ship.	✗ Constrained to Zoho's object model; changes wait on what Zoho allows.
Reliability of live balances	✓ Balances computed in our own system, in real time.	✗ Live balances depend on Zoho's sync reliability and API limits (~15–24k API calls/month at current volume).
Cost & control	✓ No per-seat licences; runs on existing infrastructure; full control of audit trail, data retention, INR/TDS handling.	✗ Per-seat licensing that grows with the team; audit trail and retention live outside our control.
Where Zoho does help	Statutory books, if needed: receive summarised entries from our ledger downstream.	✓ Strong at standard statutory accounting — the one place it genuinely fits.

The key point: buying does not remove the work. Onboarding, mapping, data formatting and reconciliation stay with us in both options — Zoho only adds a runtime dependency.

Recommendation & ask

Build the ledger natively in the marketplace as the system of record. Every financial change is stored as a new entry (never overwritten), giving us defensible point-in-time balances, flexible settlement with basic internal wallets (ledger balances only — not a full wallet product), a clean receivable/payable and margin view per party, and automated Bill of Supply, credit notes and TDS. If statutory books are required, we sync summarised entries to Zoho downstream rather than running it as the live system.

Ask: go-ahead to start Phase 1 (ledger foundation, run in parallel with current process — zero business disruption), followed by compliance automation, reconciliation & reporting, and finally surfacing the ledger to fleet owners and LSPs.